Ford Motor Company

James P. Vondale, Director
Automotive Safety Office
Environmental & Safety Engineering

January 31, 2001

Mr. Kenneth N. Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein:

Re: Ford Recall No. 01S02 -- 1999-2000 Model Year Cougar Battery Cable Misrouting

Summary

- Ford Action -- Ford is conducting a voluntary safety recall involving 1999 and 2000 model year Cougar passenger cars with 2.5L V6 engines built between December 1997 and September 2000.

- Number of Vehicles Involved -- Approximately 120,000 vehicles.

- Affect on Vehicle Operation -- If misrouted, the cable may contact the power steering line and the insulation could wear, which may result in an electrical short. An electrical short could potentially result in a fire, or in a stall or a no-start condition.

- Service Procedure -- Dealers will inspect the battery cable to the alternator for damage. If it is damaged, it will be replaced. Additionally, the routing of the cable will be corrected, as necessary, and a routing clip will be added. Finally, the torque on the alternator attachment of the cable will be checked and, as required, will be tightened to specification.

Attached is the detailed information required by the applicable portions of 49 CFR Part 573 -- Defect and Non-compliance Information Report.

Sincerely,

James P. Vondale

Attachment
01S02 5d/rjw/ae

ATTACHMENT

49 CFR Part 573 -- DEFECT INFORMATION REPORT
01S02 -- 1999-2000 MODEL YEAR COUGAR BATTERY CABLE MISROUTING

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, Ford Motor Company submits the following information concerning a safety recall action that it is voluntarily initiating.

573.5 (c) (2) -- Potentially Affected Vehicles

Certain 1999 and 2000 model year Cougar passenger cars with 2.5L V6 engines built at the Auto Alliance Assembly Plant from December 6, 1997 through September 18, 2000 are potentially affected.

Because these vehicles are not produced in VIN order, information as to the applicability of this action to specific vehicles can best be obtained by either calling Ford's toll-free line (1-800-392-3673) or contacting a local Ford dealer, who can obtain specific information regarding the vehicles from the Ford On-line Automotive Service Information System (OASIS) database.

573.5 (c) (3) -- Estimated Population of Vehicles Potentially Affected

Approximately 120,000 vehicles.

573.5 (c) (4) -- Estimated Percentage of Affected Vehicles with the Defect Condition

Unknown.

573.5 (c) (5) --Description of the Defect

If misrouted, the battery cable to the alternator could contact the metal tubing that is part of the power steering line. Repeated contact with the metal tube could wear the insulation, which may result in an electrical short. If an electrical short occurs, it could potentially result in a fire, or in a no-start or a stall.

Ford is aware of four reports of smoke or fire alleged to have resulted from this condition. In addition, there are 19 reports of melting or discoloration of the battery cable and four reports of wear on the cable. There are no reports of accidents or injuries alleged to have resulted from this condition.

573.5 (c) (6) -- Chronology of Events

Ford first became aware of this condition and began investigating it in late September 2000. The initial investigation indicated that many of the vehicles experiencing the condition had been serviced prior to the condition occurring. Further investigation conducted during late 2000 revealed that, in some cases, the condition could occur on vehicles, as produced.

573.5 (c) (8) -- Service Program

Ford will notify owners of record of affected vehicles to return vehicles to dealers for inspection and, as required, rerouting or replacement of the battery cable to the alternator. In addition, the torque on the attachment to the alternator will be checked. Ford currently anticipates that owner notification will occur on or before the week of March 5, 2001.

573.5 (c) (9) -- Press statement and Dealer/Owner Letters

Ford does not plan to make a public statement concerning this action. Notices to dealers and owners from Ford Customer Service Division will be forwarded when available.

573.5 (c) (11) -- Recall Number

Ford has assigned recall number 01S02 to this action.